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Wendell Harrison Part 1

Saxophonist and clarinetist Wendell Harrison was born in Detroit on October 1, 1942, and continues to play a key role in the city's cultural community. Wendell has performed with Sun Ra, Hank Crawford, and Marcus Belgrade, and co-founded Tribe Records in 1971.

Wendell was interviewed via Zoom on November 10, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very, very pleased to have Wendell Harrison with me today. And it requires sort of a long introduction: saxophonist and composer and record producer and community activist, and probably other things too. Kudos on your career so far.

WH: Well thank you, thank you, thank you. It's an honor to talk about my legacy and all my years in struggle, every one of them.

MR: That's — I'm struck by the fact that you just used the word struggle, because I usually try to think of a question to start with and I was going to ask do you think of your career in music and community involvement as a struggle?

WH: Yeah well the rewards — it's very rewarding. But anything that's worthwhile is a challenge. That's another word, challenge, you know. You have the many, many problems that you have to work out in terms of presenting this music and archiving it and documenting it and trying to get it out to a wider audience. A wider audience. And, which is recordings and CDs and, nowadays you're talking about streaming and all kinds of different formats. I'm doing a video now, of my legacy, which is like 65 years of activities. So often times I'll look at it as a challenge and struggle you know, and a problem that you solve you know. And you have to be consistent and you have to garner all kinds of help you know around you, your community, you have to reach out, you know. It's really a job. Really a job.

MR: I read something about when you had the publication, the Tribe publication and you had used the word "relegate." You have to learn how to relegate some things or you're going to lose your mind.

WH: Yeah. You have to get help or expedite you know, the different responsibilities. Because I'm a saxophone player. I'm chasing notes, you know what I mean? And you know in this quest of playing the saxophone and dealing with the jazz language you know, I have to call on different other avenues of like in media, publishing, people that is an expert in that particular area and have skills in that particular area. I had to like actually create a network of, create a network of — like Eddie Harris would say, create an army of

sergeants that can help. Because he was very — of course the great Eddie Harris — we were very close. We recorded and toured together for a long time. And every city Eddie would have, he would call a sergeant or a help in every state, city and state, he would have people helping him dealing with concerts and workshops, and so it was easy for him when every time he would tour he would get many big engagements from big agencies out of New York but he would always call on these people in these cities to help set up a tour. Same when I worked with Hank Crawford you know. Hank Crawford would have an agency called the Shaw Artists out of New York that deal with major — so they would give him about five different major festivals. But in between the festivals is like — there's a hole in our itinerary.

MR: Yeah it's hard to keep a band together also when you have all those holes in the schedule.

WH: Yeah, yeah. But depending on where we were, he had his road management call different venues in these different little cities and whatnot that would fill in the gap you know. So we was working constantly. Constantly working. It's like a network that you have to set up. Being an artist, especially an independent artist, you have to have a network. Just like a record company. A record company has a network like say for instance Blue Note Records. You know, or Columbia Records. They put a release out but they have many, many they contract with many, many other distributors and record companies to actually get that record out all over the world. Back in the day, when the record company was paramount — I'm talking about 30 years ago — they would actually, in one record, and they would put that record out and once they got going they put that record out in three days all over the world. All over the world in three days. In three days you were a known entity you know.

MR: Can I take you back for a moment — I'm wondering if there was a specific recording or incident where music got into your head. Do you remember one of the first things that made an impression on you musically, as a kid?

WH: As a kid?

MR: As a kid.

WH: I was fortunate. As a kid. Well I had a different experience probably. I played piano at five years old. My parents started me playing the piano because I was a nervous kid running around. And they would take me shopping and I was so crazy I would just pull the groceries off the shelves and put them on the floor. You know I was hard to contain you know. And concentration was like a gnat, I couldn't concentrate on anything. So when people say well give him a piano, take him — he needs discipline. He needs to be able to concentrate. So I started playing piano at the age of five and actually took piano lessons, and it helped. So my grandfather says, "Doing good." So I was eight years old and they said, "Give him a clarinet." He bought me a clarinet. See how that works. So I

got a clarinet. I'm playing it to this day, the clarinet. So I started playing that in elementary school. But the thing is, because I had to sit still and decipher notes on the page, that was a job for me. It was a job you know. I didn't like it. But I concentrated and when I concentrated I got rewards. And then when I got in middle school we got — we had these different performances, we called them like assemblies where like we would play for plays and you'd play for dance shows and so I got attention because at that time I was playing first clarinet. And the girls would come up and talk to me because I was on display you know. And oh I liked that. What a way to go, you know, I'm getting attention now. So the rewards, if I practiced good and got these shows and stuff I would get accolades and whatnot, and I would get attention from the girls. I would say, "This works." So I started playing more and practicing. Then when I got to high school I met guys that was playing bebop. Like I don't know if you know Charles McPherson?

MR: Yes I do.

WH: Lonnie Hillyer, Roy Brooks and those guys was in high school — they was like two years ahead of me. But every — like 7:30 in the morning they would be playing in the boiler room. This was back in the 50s. Because jazz wasn't allowed to be played in the band room because the band director was nervous. He couldn't stand to hear Charlie Parker's work. "Cherokee" and "Donna Lee" and all that stuff. And these guys was playing the carbon copy of the record you know.

MR: They were learning by ear, is that right?

WH: They could read you see. There was always, at that particular time, it was required to read. Reading marches, classical stuff, and everybody was required to take private lessons then. I'm talking about the 40s and 50s. In other words in order to get into the band, there was a B band, an A band, you'd have a private teacher. That was a requirement. So then when you joined the band they would teach you, you could play these tunes. But there was no thing about learning to play the instrument you know. It was learning the music, not the instrument. The instrument, it was understood that you could play and you could read. So playing in the band is about interpretation, learning to interpret. Because we was playing music from Italy, Germany, all over you know. A wide repertoire of music you know, very good educational system because they introduced you to different cultures and whatnot. So in terms of — these guys were playing music and they would write out different — they could write. We learned how to write. Because they had studied with the great Barry Harris. You know. And they had older musicians that was — this was in Detroit — they had older musicians that were working in Detroit and they would go to New York to record for Blue Note or Columbia or wherever it would be, or Riverside or Impulse, and then they'd come back to Detroit and work because of the auto industry, the economy was so big here. It was hot back in the 50s you

113 know. The people was making money and people was working you know. People buying
114 homes and forming businesses and creating businesses. So the infrastructure and the
115 environment was very ludicrous [lucrative?] — actually prolific back in those days you
116 know. People used to come in from the south and as far as Poland to come and work in
117 the factory. People like Berry Gordy. He was working in the factory and he started
118 Motown. A lot of businesses started as a byproduct of the auto industry.
119 MR: Was there a point that you said to yourself and maybe to your parents or your family that
120 I think I'm going to make a career of this?
121 WH: Yeah. Well first of all I had to stop playing the clarinet. Because the kids, well they were
122 about 17, 18 and I was like maybe 15, 14, 16 you know. Say "Wendell, Benny Goodman
123 is all right, they've got a young baby boy that's trying to beat Benny Goodman. You need
124 to listen to Charlie Parker if you want to play." Because I was surprised he could play
125 real fast tempos, man they could really play, and one guy sounded like a carbon copy of
126 Dizzy Gillespie and Chuck. Charles McPherson was sounding exactly like Bird under the
127 tutelage of Barry Harris you know. And so I was so amazed at that and I begged my
128 mother, I said, "Momma, momma, momma, I got to have an alto saxophone. I want to
129 study Charlie Parker." And she said, "I don't know about it. Well you've been playing for
130 piano lessons and we bought you a clarinet and you've got clarinet lessons and now you
131 want a saxophone?" So she thought about it and she came back and said, "Well I'll get
132 you a saxophone but you've got to have a job." So she got a paper route and I started
133 delivering papers. And then with that, that wasn't bad enough, I got a stock boy job
134 stocking food, you know, in the grocery. Because a grocery boy. At about, I was like 13,
135 okay? About 13. So I did that and she got this Martin alto saxophone. And I started
136 playing, playing, playing, practicing. Because they would give me ideas to play, and they
137 gave me tunes that I had to learn. I had to build up my jazz vocabulary, repertoire. And at
138 that point I started playing with other musicians or students of jazz, that was already
139 playing. They discovered that I was playing saxophone and I was pretty good you know.
140 So they asked me to join their band and they were playing like little dances, like proms
141 and weddings and community stuff. And they would get a lot of work because they was
142 kids, they were young. They were like 17, 18 you know.
143 MR: What would the song list have been like? And do you recall how much money you first
144 made? Your first gig? Your first paying gig?
145 WH: Oh this was amazing. Because back in those days they were dancing, social dancing.
146 When you play for a dance, you know there's social dancing, we played "Out of
147 Nowhere," we played "Caravan," we would play, for instance we would play "How High
148 the Moon" but then we discovered that Charlie Parker wrote a tune on "How High the
149 Moon" and he called it "Ornithology." So at the same time as I was playing these tunes I

would go home with this other group, you know we'd practice with this other group at school. Not go home, I'd go to school. And the other group was playing "Ornithology" and "Hot House" and "Donna Lee." And I discovered that it was the same as those standards they was playing at the dances. So we would play these tunes but then I would play the bebop tunes and they would play the traditional Cole Porter, Rogers & Hart melody, and we would play the bebop tunes along with them. You know that's how, we learned them together. We learned the bebop and we learned the original tunes together. A contrafact. Today they call it a contrafact.

MR: Yes. Were rhythm & blues creeping into things that people wanted to hear at that time?

WH: No this was like rhythm & blues — do you know the original rhythm & blues is? The original R & B was rhythm changes. Like "I Got Rhythm?" And you had about a thousand tunes that was written basically on that format. You know it's modified from one tune to the next but basically that, "I Got Rhythm" and it's like a 32-bar form. Okay. There were so many tunes back in the 30s and 40s that was based on that 32-bar form, with different variations, different variations you know, different keys and then sometimes the jazz musicians would introduce substitution changes and whatnot, because they was trying to deal with their sound, more of a modern progressive sound. And so that was like the rhythm format, and then you had the blues format which is a 12-bar format. And you had a thousand, a million —

MR: You could play the blues all night.

WH: Yeah well there's so many different kinds of blues, we have blues with bridges you have blues that's got 12-bar blues and sometimes they would extend it to like playing 12 bars and then play a 4-bar interlude. You know you had all different kinds of — but that was the popular sound of that particular time. And then at the same time there was rock & roll. Frankie Valli, let's see, Chuck Berry —

MR: Little Richard.

WH: Little Richard, okay, Little Richard. But it was still the 12-bar blues.

MR: Yes.

WH: Still the 12-bar blues. And sometimes, like Ray Charles, sometimes the 12-bar blues would be extended to 16 bars you know, and then you would hear, if you played for church you would hear the same format in churches playing the same formal changes. In fact the church, in the Baptist church, they usually adapt to the music or sound that's popular and then put spiritual words on top of that. You know if you have a big popular tune that's in the psyche of everybody they would actually put, somebody would construct a tune which is similar chord-wise and put lyrics, spiritual lyrics on top of it. And it would really serve the purpose of church. Everybody felt good — "Oh that really sounds good." And they would really go out and buy church music. But they were buying

the same music, you know it's the same format. So the original R & B, rhythm & blues, was like popular music, 40s and 50s, and I mean the popular music not only blues stuff like Little Richard, but I'm talking about Cole Porter, Rogers & Hart, Gershwin. Those were the major composers at that particular time. And we took those tunes and dressed them up, instead of doing swing we'd play bossa nova, we'd play Latin, we'd play shuffle and change the beat.

MR: Did your piano lessons help make sense of chords, chord changes and so forth, once you really got into the quest to be an improviser?

WH: Oh wow, that's a profound statement. Everything begins and ends with the piano. Now me playing piano at five years old, because that enabled me, the piano was my friend you know? I knew about the piano. So when I got the saxophone and I started playing these ideas on a saxophone, these guys would take me, they'd say, "Well you've got to go to the piano and work these tunes out first before we go any further. You have to learn the changes on the piano, you know, because I could read piano music, but it wasn't about — the music at that time was about chords, learning how to build a chord, like a major, minor, augmented. And then after you do that you learn how to voice it so it won't sound so crazy. So everything in jazz, from a practitioner, revolves around the piano. The piano is your source. Because when you see — you can play the piano, you can play chords and then you play the ideas against the chords on the piano. You can see it. But you can't see it with a trumpet or saxophone or those other instruments. The piano gives you a graphic knowledge of what you're doing you know. So a good musician always has to have knowledge of the piano. You know. Because that's your format, that's your source. When you go to figure out a tune you go to the piano. You don't go to your horn, you go to the piano to figure it out. And then you pick up an instrument, after you work it out on the piano and you see how it's making sense. You have to see the flow of the chords and stuff like that, and see where it's going and where it's ending and how the melody fits in with the chords. And then you go to your instrument and start playing. Another thing, when you start playing and orchestrating for a big band or ensembles and stuff, you go to the piano and say well, man, the ensemble was just like my ten fingers.

MR: Right. You know here's the saxophones.

WH: This is the brass over here and the reeds over here. And then you learn how to score. You put all this stuff in the score, that's a whole different thing. I went to the Conservatory before I moved to New York. I was like 18 years old and I went to the Conservatory and I learned keyboard harmony and solfeggio and all that you know. And I learned how to write European music you know. Stravinsky or let's say Beethoven or Mozart. I learned how to put it together. So now as I said, well how can I learn Duke Ellington and Count Basie or Oliver Nelson? They say, "Well we don't teach that here." This was in the 50s

see? Jazz wasn't even considered music in a lot of camps you know. It was like rap music today, you know it was like, oh wow, that's a whole different world, you know, ether. So I say, "Well that's my interest." So I went to New York and I learned from other musicians I was working with, Duke Ellington, working with Count Basie, and big bands. Ray Charles. And they was writing. They was writing for different groups and whatnot. Because like if you go to New York, at that particular time, you could actually — if you could solo that was good, but you had to be able to read, you had to be able to see. You had to sight read.

MR: Right.

WH: And you had to be adaptable, you had to adapt a feeling. And you had to be able to solo. But if you could write arrangements that would give you another source of income you know, so you've got to learn how to score and write charts for a singer. You start out with a singer, you know. Actually you start out with a six piece to a five piece horn section with rhythm, and you start learning how to orchestrate stuff and treating the brass one way and treating the reeds another way, and making music, and you start writing, getting jobs writing for singers and then occasionally you'd get big band work and whatnot. So it was really, all this was really supporting yourself as a musician. You had to do all these — I call them like "lifejackets." If you could play — because a lot of bands just wanted a soloist you know. Because guys couldn't read so much but he can solo.

MR: Yeah those days were over. I wanted to ask you, you went there in 1960?

WH: '60. Yeah.

MR: Okay. In 1959 and '61, sort of surrounding, we had these records, "The Shape of Jazz to Come," "Giant Steps," "Kind of Blue" and then in '61 we had "We Insist" Max Roach, and "Free Jazz" by Ornette Coleman. My question is we look at these albums now as iconic and artistic achievements, did they have any impact on your musical thinking at that time?

WH: Oh my God yes they did. Because when I went to New York I was very regimented in a way, because I was like into bebop and playing the changes. Everything was about changes and reading. But then, being in New York, you know we had a variety of different jazz concepts. We called it jazz but the different concepts under the umbrella of jazz. And they called me to do a job with Sun Ra. You remember Sun Ra?

MR: Yes indeed. I was going to ask about Sun Ra.

WH: So that was frightening for me, when I went with Sun Ra.

MR: When you first arrived it was frightening to you, like did you go to a rehearsal first or did you just land in a gig?

WH: Oh when I first moved to New York I started working with Grant Green. Guitarist for Blue Note Records, he played bebop guitar. And he had Bob Cranshaw, Bob

Cunningham and Ben Dixon on drums and on tour instead he got an organ. Then sometimes we would play gigs with an organ. And then I got gigs with Hank Crawford. Now this was '63. But meanwhile I would take little gigs with Sun Ra, with John Gilmore playing saxophone. Actually John Gilmore had went with Trane — I mean Art Blakey. He went with Art Blakey. And Sun Ra was using Pharoah but Trane was calling him all the time. John Coltrane was calling him all the time. So there I was, about the same age. So they tried me out and so Sun Ra'd say, "Don't play. I don't want you to solo. Just play the notes." Because he's writing notes that I could read, because — and he said, "When you solo I don't want to hear a bunch of exercises. I don't want to hear a bunch of exercises, I want to hear imagery." I say wow, imagery, what is that? So he said, "Think of a Godzilla throwing the lady out the Empire State Building" or "think about a nice pretty lady walking the beach" or "think about some warm soup." What kind of feeling does that have? Project that kind of feeling. Or project a train wreck or a car wreck. You know what I mean? Put that into your expression and the emotions of it. I mean play the emotions and the spiritual feeling of that.

MR: May I ask if that's the first time, first significant time that the idea of emotion and expression was introduced to you and came out of your horn?

WH: No — I had to work on it. I mean he was telling me how to play and how to think. And he's talking about this spiritual stuff, and he's talking about emotions. But I had to think what can I play that would arouse a feeling? And what kind of feeling would it be? Can I do it with a squeak? Can I do it with a squeak or a honk? You know or can I growl in the horn, you learn how to growl, two, three different kinds of growls and stuff. Because music is very emotional. If you have the skill to project and draw the feeling out of the music it affects your listener. It means more to your listener.

MR: Does it change the idea of a mistake?

WH: No mistakes. But I mean you have to give it, like even Miles, even like Miles say there is no such thing as a wrong note.

Would you excuse me for one minute?

MR: You were talking about the idea of wrong notes and mistakes and how that has changed over the years because, going back to the piano how you can see a C sharp over a G chord and it has that certain sound. At the time you might have thought well that's a mistake but maybe no longer.

WH: Well the thing is wrong notes and wrong chords, it depends on how you play that note rhythm-wise and if it's going to be the last note — if that note you're concerned with, is it the last note or the first note? If it's the first note you can resolve it. You know what I mean? And if you don't want to resolve it you can put a chord with it and make it good. Make it fine you know, and could that be a start of another phrase, that wrong note might

be a start of another phrase. It depends how you treat that note that's in question. It depends how you treat it. And as a jazz musician you learn how to play these notes and make sense out of them. Because as a jazz musician you're making mistakes all along because you're not playing things that you played — you're always reaching for new phrases and whatnot, that you haven't played before. I mean that's just the nature of who we are. So we always — if you're going to use the word "mistake" we're always changing mistakes and making it into something that's acceptable. So when you look back again there's no such thing as a mistake. I wasn't finished. I wasn't finished. And the thing is our ego is built on changing ideas, changing phrases and stuff, and really making something that's acceptable to the ear. Because the note that's in question might get an emotional reaction. It's useful. You might get a spiritual reaction. You might say it's a wrong note but what does that do? There's only wrong if something's been documented for years. Like sheet music or standards or something like that. And it's been documented for years and you're playing, and you don't play the note, you don't play the copyrighted note, the copy written note that's in the let's say lead sheet. "Oh man that's wrong?" If you're trying to perform the same music "as is."

MR: That reminds me of Miles when he'd play "Autumn Leaves" and instead of going [scats] he went [scats].

WH: Yeah. Flat five.

MR: Yeah. And you think well Miles can do that.

WH: Yeah. Well and it reinforces his identity and his approach. You know he does that, Miles. So as soon as somebody else plays the same way he said, "Well he's copying Miles" or "he's playing Miles." You know? Same with Trane, the different ideas Trane had. You know sometimes Trane would play — Trane made four or five different transitions in his playing. I was studying Sonny Rollins and then I started listening to Trane when I was 17, 18 years old, in Detroit you know. And I was copying these ideas. "Trane did this oh wow, played this blues with Miles Davis." He was playing "'Round About Midnight" he was playing "Shiny Stockings" or Hoagy Carmichael, "Stardust."

MR: "Stardust." Uh huh.

WH: So the way he treated that language. I mean he had his own language. So at that time I had to leave Barry Harris because he didn't want to hear that in his house. "No Trane in my house." And I don't want no Loony Tunes in my house. I said oh man, and Trane was hot at that time. Trane was — I mean every young musician wanted to play like that. We was playing Bird but here Trane came along. Trane came along. And that was the new sound. And this was like during Civil Rights, it was like the soundtrack of the community or the nation. Because Trane projected struggle. He projected struggle and he projected a lot of emotions in his playing. So we gravitated toward that because we tried to be — it's

all about emotions you know. And he was projecting that. And bebop is more like — bebop was more romantic. But Trane wasn't in a romantic frame of mind with all these rights and stuff going on.

MR: What was his frame of mind for you?

WH: It was civil unrest. Well he was very spiritual but the thing is a musician plays the life of the environment. He was affected from the environment. You know I'm talking about people like Martin Luther King and all the struggles that went in terms of civil rights or voting rights or women. We struggle with that today. You know? Same thing. It never ends. And then everybody was very spiritual too at that particular time. Because to play the music I think you had to have a spiritual awareness about you. These guys have their own way of doing things. Even Sonny Rollins, Sonny was changing too where he was very rooted, he became a star, playing the bebop thing, and it was hard for him to do too much changing. Same with Yusef — well Yusef Lateef, he changed. Yusef was one of the profound saxophone players in the 40s that changed and what I'm saying is finally he was very popular. And his playing changed quite a bit. But he always had, up until recently he always had that bebop approach. Same with Sonny Rollins. Sonny came after him.

MR: I'd like to get at an issue and start with a quote. The issue is the role of jazz in society and how society affects jazz. And this is a quote from Max Roach that was connected to the "We Insist Freedom Now" LP, it was 1962. And he said "We American jazz musicians of African descent have proved beyond all doubt that we're master musicians of our instruments. Now what we have to do is employ our skill to tell the dramatic story of our people and what we've been through." So my question to you is did that music like Max Roach's affect you and did you feel that it was a direction you wanted to go in or felt compelled to go in?

WH: I admired Max. Sun Ra was more influential in terms of he affected my direction more than Max. Trane did. I liked Mingus but everybody was doing the same — had the same purpose but different ways of approaching to try to play freer, trying to play freer. And this meant, in terms of changing the format, like for instance Horace Silver, he'd just play — Horace Silver was very popular. He was a business guy. And he'd play and wrote tunes that sold. He had his own publishing — he was one of the first black musicians that had his own publishing company. And he was more interested in selling his music to the popular players in the world. Max or Trane, for instance Trane, Trane was more academic in terms of projecting the spiritual ideas and the reflection of pain and suffering of the community and bringing attention to these events that was happening down south like Alabama, Mississippi and Georgia and whatnot, bringing the events. He was telling the musical story of what was happening. And that kind of like influenced me you know.

Because I produced a record called "Evening with the Devil" in 1970 which had "Mary Had an Abortion." This was "Mary Had an Abortion," which was a poem. But the first one was written by myself, which was a reflection of Africa being Mary and having an abortion of a people, undeveloped people, and that was the first poem that was recited by me. And then I employed a group of actors, it was something like The Last Poets, which wrote a tune, "Mary Had an Abortion."

MR: Yeah, guess what I was listening to about two hours ago?

WH: Huh?

MR: That song. And I was trying to figure out the first thing I hear, I think it's that particular cut, and the first thing I hear I'm trying to figure out now what is that? Is that an acoustic bass with a bow?

WH: Yeah.

MR: Is that was it is? Very mysterious.

WH: He was playing down on the bridge, on the bridge, with a bow and he's playing. So you heard the poem?

MR: I did. And then I was listening to the rest of the song, and I had this question here, I'll read my question because I think you answered it. Is it possible to play "out" or "free" but not play aggressively?

WH: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. Because on that cut I heard it. I'm not sure which trumpet player it was but at any rate it was like a little road map of different styles and I wondered what the music looked like because there was times when everybody was playing together like you wrote a musical marker. And I almost pictured the recording session like maybe people were improvising, it was freer, and then you're cuing in — okay we're moving on here. Am I like hallucinating here?

WH: No, no, back in the — the way we played, when we did a concert, in fact the record is like from a concert. In other words when we did a concert it was a continuous music, going from one tune to the next. And we started with "Mary had an Abortion" and that was real fast tempo right? Real fast tempo. And the chorus was going down in minor thirds, like a B flat major to G major to E major to D flat major, repeated over and over and over again, and we're writing lines on this. We'd play [scats] and we kept on playing and then that was the first time, and then we'd put the poetry on top of that. And then we settled down and went into a tune called "Where Am I." We're in this new land over here. You know this new land of North America. Where am I. And it's like a tune of discovery. You know everything is cerebral or whatnot. We wrote words to it [sings] Where am I now that I'm in this new day/how do it get to know a change in me/how do I get to know you/just say I am. Harold McKinney wrote that a little later you know. But

the tune, music keeps developing. We had different pieces over the years, we had, we'd revisit these tunes and add different things to it, different tunes and different melodies, lyrics and whatnot, changed a different chords and whatnot. You keep adding to it. Now after "Where Am I" it goes into a tune called "Angry Young Man" which is in 6/8. But the same changes as "Mary Had an Abortion" but it's in 6/8 now. Instead of [claps fast] we had [claps slow] we had 6/8 [scats] Same thing [scats] it's the same format but played different. And at the end of this format, at the end of this tune Marcus Belgrave takes a solo on that and I take a solo in 6/8. Same changes going down. We played, on this particular cut we played actual changes pretty much. We're playing that major to the G to the E to the D flat and find out how many ways we can manipulate and negotiate.

MR: Negotiate. I like that word.

WH: See you know what I mean? So and then that settles down into a tune called "Consciousness" which talks about police brutality which is the "Angry Young Man," or "Consciousness" you know, and this back in the day he was talking about "Purple Haze." Did you hear that? The "Purple Haze?"

MR: I didn't hear that part.

WH: It talks about Irish nightsticks, he'd been hit on the head with an Irish nightstick and so it's a whole poem that deals with the whole police culture. It's just a couple of minutes, about two, three minutes. Then it goes into a classical — the finale is a classical sound.

MR: Yes, that really struck me, like what's the idea behind that? Like all of a sudden there's these mostly major chords and if they were played by a string section it could have been Haydn or something.

WH: Yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: Why did you do that?

WH: Well we were in the European world. We're reflecting the environment. You know what I mean? And it's majestic. It has a majestic sound, talking about King James and the whole regime, the whole environment or the whole world that that reflects. You know what I mean? And the thing is, Monk, it's just a suite. It's just an idea.

MR: May I read a quote from you connected to this recording? You said, now this is 1972, correct?

WH: Right.

MR: "We hope to bring out points, situations and events that are happening in our communities by way or music, poetry and dance and rapping to the people. You cannot divorce art from its root culture and expect it to be relevant to both the artist and his culture."

WH: That was what I was trying to say. That's what I was trying to say. But that's what the artist, to me, the artist is. Like a painter? A musician or a sculpturer they are affected by

the environment. Now you have other artists that just play or create art for the purpose of marketing and selling. You say well I'm going to create this music because I know I'm going to put this music together in a way that it's going to reach a certain market and I'm going to sell it to this market, because I know what they want. So you have artists, like smooth jazz artists maybe, like today, that will create music for that because they know they can get a lot of money, if they can get a deal to put it out and they can make people feel good. It's like an antidote. It's the same as selling liquor. It makes you feel good, you know what I mean, and it's party time and anesthesia, you know, in a way.

MR: Yes. Benny Powell said, "No art was ever created by happy people."

WH: Wow, wow.

MR: That's heavy.

WH: That's heavy. That's really heavy. Often times we are sensitive. That word happy, I struggle with that word happy because when I'm writing music I'm satisfied and I'm at my best when I'm writing music and I feel secure with myself as a musician when I'm writing. And it's very rewarding when I get the music played back you know. Me as a person, I'm not a comedian, my life is not a comic. When you say happy that means jovialness and — well I'm saying we're not happy if he used the word happy — we're not happy all the time as human beings. I think he just said that to point out certain instances where we have it — because our spirit is constantly moving. The spirit is constantly changing and whatnot, it depends on how we respond to our environment. We don't have a happy environment. Sometimes we'll be happy. Sometimes we take kids to a music park, a museum or take kids to a playground or something like that. That could be a happy mood. Oh then we have to go to a funeral you know. We are affected all kinds of ways.

MR: Maybe the word content would be a little more appropriate. But I had another thought I'd like to ask you, if spirituality can inspire music and a way of playing, can it work the other way around? If you decide to play in a manner that you hear Coltrane and others doing could that lead to spirituality in your own life?

WH: Wow. No the sound is a reflection of how he's feeling and his spiritual awareness. It has nothing to do with the listener unless the listener is into where he's coming from, but everybody has their own experience. Everybody has their own experience and their own reality. Now he might play some stuff reminiscent of the Birmingham bombing, maybe he's reflecting on that, which might be more solemn or lamenting you know what I mean? It could be more lamenting. But it might — another person might hear it very romantic.

MR: True. Yeah.

WH: It depends on the experience. See music is abstract and it's tools that you can use to deal with emotion but the emotions don't have to conjure up the same reality. You know what you might project as tension might be a different tension I imagine when I hear it. You know. It's tension but it might be the tension of a car accident or something, you know what I mean? You know I mean but we're dealing with people — everybody's got their own spiritual way. We was made as individuals. The creator made us all as individuals. We had our own interpretation of the spirit or the God or the creator, you call it creator you know. And we have allegiance to that. It's the same story but everybody has a different relationship and concept, a different relationship and concept, but we all come from the same source. Does that make sense?

MR: Yes. And I wonder, I was thinking of some of the late Coltrane like the Olatunji Center and very late, and people may listen to that and one person may think what is he so angry about and the next person may get a totally different — that he's being ecstatic about — he's having an experience, a spiritual experience. So I guess it's in the ear of the listener.

WH: Yeah. Because everybody perceives different, the perception is different. It was based on your experience. If you have an experience [inaudible] John is an experience. He's projecting these notes and this sound, and he's motivated one way, you know but you might take it — unless he speaks on it, unless he speaks on it, unless he says something. You're going to take it different. And that's the beauty of sound, it's an attribute of the total creator. You know it's big. The sound is bigger than all of us you know what I mean?

MR: You just made me think of something that I should have thought of many years ago. If he spoke on it. And I wonder now if the "Love Supreme" record reached so many people because he announced his intention.

WH: Well you say "A Love Supreme?"

MR: Yes.

WH: That's spiritual.

MR: It's very spiritual.

WH: But the supreme to you, what does that mean? It might be — your supreme might be different from my supreme, based on our experience, based on our knowledge of, based on our knowledge, and intellect and intuition, intuition, intuition. There's a lot of stuff we believe in that we can't really see. We have faith. Faith is belief. We believe in something. It might not be manifested physically but we believe in it. That's very important as a musician. You know. I believe these notes is going to take care of me, you know what I mean?

MR: Can you say that again?

WH: I believe these notes that I produce is going to take care of me. You know, and I have to make sure of that.

MR: That's very quotable, Wendell, that's very quotable.

WH: That's why you're always chasing these notes, you know what I'm saying? In a way.

MR: "Chasin' the Train" and chasing the notes.

WH: Yeah because I'm harnessing and I'm trying to capture the sound and what that would be, the feeling and stuff like that you know, and where we were talking about making it take care of us and where we're living now, it has to be harnessed to — of course nowadays film, video, TV, CDs, any form, all forms of ideal distribution. And we have to make sure that happens in the world we live in today you know.

MR: On that note I'm going to pause our recording for a second.